Narrative

Elements of Narrative: Setting

The **setting** of a movie is the time and place in which the story occurs. It establishes the date, city, or country and provides the characters' social, educational, and cultural backgrounds and other identifying factors vital for understanding them—such as what they wear, eat, and drink. Setting sometimes provides an implicit explanation for actions or traits that we might otherwise consider eccentric, because cultural norms vary from place to place and throughout time. Certain genres are associated with specific settings; for example, Westerns with wide open country, film noirs with dark city streets, and horror movies with creepy houses.

Besides giving us essential contextual information that helps us understand story events and character motivation, setting adds texture to the movie's diegesis, enriching our sense of the overall world of the movie. Settings are not always drawn from real-life locales. The attraction of science-fiction films such as George Lucas's *Star Wars* (1977) and Ridley Scott's *Blade Runner* (1982) is often attributed to their almost totally unfamiliar settings. These stories about outer space and future cities have a mythical or symbolic significance beyond that of stories set on Earth. Their settings may be verisimilar and appropriate for the purpose of the story, whether or not we can verify them as "real."

Based on Philip K. Dick's science-fiction novel *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* (1968), Ridley Scott's *Blade Runner* (1982) takes place in 2019 in an imaginary world where cities such as Los Angeles are ruled by technology and saturated with visual information. In most science-fiction films, setting plays an important part in our understanding of the narrative, so sci-fi filmmakers spend considerable time, money, and effort to make the setting come to life.

***Blade Runner* (Ridley Scott, 1982)**

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